Vaishnavite gods too, such as Rama, Krishna and Lord Venkateshvara of Tirupati, as well as Jain temples. They also made room for Islam in their realm—a certain Ahmed Khan built a mosque in 1439 in Vijayanagar's 'urban core'; its ruins and nearby tombs still stand.[6]

There are other variants of this origin story, but whatever the truth of its founding, there is no doubt that the Sangama brothers, first Hakka, aka Harihara I (r. 1336–56), then Bukka Raya (r. 1356–77), laid the foundations of a great capital city and empire. Bukka Raya's realm had grown large enough that he felt secure in claiming the following titles for himself: 'the prosperous great tributary, punisher of enemy kings, Sultan among Hindu Kings, vanquisher of kings who break their word, lord of the eastern and western oceans, the auspicious hero'.[7]

Thus began a new era of shifting imperial fortunes and alliances, more intense warfare with both Hindu and Muslim kings, coups and rebellions, internecine rivalries and murders. As described in the following pages, this was a time of great syncretic innovation in Vijayanagar, particularly in courtly culture, governance, military organization and architecture. People saw greater geographic mobility and economic opportunity. The city presided over a rich and diverse flowering of art, literature and culture, including the birth of Carnatic music. With perhaps 250,000 residents at its height in the early sixteenth century, Vijayanagar became one of the largest cities in the world. Four dynasties would eventually rule the Vijayanagar Empire: Sangama (1336–1485), Saluva (1485–1505), Tuluva (1505–1570) and Aravidu (1570–1652).

Chroniclers of the age report a series of brutal wars, many between Vijayanagar and the Bahmani Sultanate. Both coveted the fertile land between the Tungabhadra and Krishna rivers, whose fortress town of Raichur kept switching masters. Bloody conflicts here continued even after Krishnadevaraya defeated the already disintegrating Bahmani Sultanate, splitting it into five Deccan Sultanates in 1518—Golkonda, Bijapur, Bidar, Berar and Ahmadnagar. Religion played a role in these wars, but was rarely the dominant cause. Examples abound of Muslims fighting Muslims; Hindus fighting Hindus; Hindus joining Muslims to fight Hindus; Muslims joining Hindus to fight Muslims; Brahmins held great sway in the governance of some Deccan sultanates. Vijayanagar's armies had lots of